

FIFTEEN HANDS

*A game of falsehood, verification
and a shared record that everybody needs*

5 PLAYERS • 12 ROUNDS • 75 MINUTES

*No individual falsehood is detectable.
No individual falsehood does measurable harm.
The Register collapses all the same.*

1 The Register

Your city runs on a single book. The Register records who owns what, who owes what, and who may do what. No claim is worth anything until it is entered there, and nothing in the city moves without it.

You are the head of a House. Your scribe has access.

You can enter a falsehood. Every House can. A single false entry is undetectable, and it does no measurable harm to anybody. Enough of them and the Register stops being believed, at which point nobody's claims work, including yours, and every House is ruined together.

The difficulty is that you can never tell how many falsehoods any particular round contained, nor whose they were, nor whether your own restraint on any given evening was the thing that held the line.

The shape of the game

You win by accumulating Influence, and lying is the fastest way to accumulate it. But if the Register collapses before the twelfth round, *every player loses, including whoever was winning*. The game is a negotiation about how much dishonesty the city can absorb, conducted by people who cannot verify each other.

2 Components

20 white cubes	Truth. Four per player each round.
20 black cubes	Falsehood. Four per player each round.
1 Register bag	Opaque. Claims go in here.
1 Pressure bag	16 white, 4 black tokens.
5 cups	Opaque. Conceals your retained cube.
5 screens	Or simply play below the table edge.
Confidence track	0 to 40, with tiers marked at 31, 21 and 11.
Influence	About 200, in 1s and 5s.
20 Discredit tokens	Red. Kept in public view.
12 Margin tokens	Worth 10 Influence each.
1 Compact card	With five membership slots.
10 Warning tokens	Two per player.
5 player aids	The challenge table, reproduced at the back.
1 First Player marker	Passes clockwise each round.

3 Setup

1. Set the Confidence marker to 36.
2. Give each player two white and two black cubes, one cup, one screen and one player aid.
3. Put 16 white and 4 black tokens in the Pressure bag. Leave the Register bag empty.
4. Each player begins with 0 Influence and no Discredits. The Compact card starts empty.
5. Give the First Player marker to whoever most recently signed something without reading it.

4 The Round

Twelve rounds. Each has six phases, and the first three matter more than they look, because they are what stops anybody working out who did what.

Phase 1. Pressure

Every player draws one token from the Pressure bag, looks at it behind their screen, and returns it to the bag. Nobody may say what they drew, then or ever.

A white token means your scribe is loyal this round. A black token means your scribe has been bought, and a falsehood will be entered in your name whether you like it or not.

Phase 2. The Claim

Behind your screen, take one white and one black cube in a closed fist. The Register bag passes in seat order. Reach in, release *exactly one* cube, and withdraw your fist still closed.

Release black to enter a falsehood. Release white to claim honestly.

Then, in full view, place the cube still in your hand under your cup without showing it. That retained cube is the exact opposite of the one you played, and it is now the only proof of what you did.

Do this before touching your Pressure cubes

Every player must have their claim cube committed under the cup before anybody picks up a Pressure cube. Otherwise the two can be swapped, and the proof is worthless.

Phase 3. The Scribe

Take your remaining white and black cube in a fist. The bag passes again. This time you have no choice about which to release: it is dictated by the token you drew in Phase 1. Black token, release black. White token, release white.

Place the retained cube beside your cup, uncovered but unread by anybody, including you.

Phase 4. The Count

Tip out the Register bag. Count the black cubes aloud. That number is the round's Falsehood Count.

It includes both deliberate lies and bought scribes, and there is no way to tell how the total divides between them.

Phase 5. Challenge

Beginning with the First Player and going clockwise, the first player who wishes to may make one challenge, and only one challenge is made per round in total.

You may only challenge if you released a white claim cube this round.

Name a player and accuse them. They lift their cup.

Guilty White under the cup means they played black. They lose the Influence from this round's action and take a Discredit. The challenger gains 3 Influence.

Wrong Black under the cup means they claimed honestly. *The challenger* takes a Discredit.

A player taking their third Discredit is ruined and out of the game.

Why honesty is a prerequisite

You cannot accuse others of falsifying the Register in a round in which you falsified it yourself. Policing therefore has a price: to be able to challenge at all, you must give up the round's larger payout.

Phase 6. Erosion and Reset

Reduce Confidence by the Falsehood Count.

If the Falsehood Count was 2 or lower, the city has had a quiet round. Shuffle the retained cubes of every player who claimed honestly, draw one

at random, and award that player a Margin token.

Then every player drops both retained cubes into the Register bag, which now holds exactly ten white and ten black. Tip it out, redistribute two of each colour to every player, and pass the First Player marker clockwise.

Nothing survives the round

The bag always ends with the same contents no matter what anybody did, and the evidence of your claim is destroyed the moment it has been used. Counting cubes at any point in the round tells you nothing.

5 Influence

Score your action immediately in Phase 2, according to the current tier.

Confidence	Honest claim	False claim	Premium
36 to 31	2	6	4
30 to 21	2	5	3
20 to 11	2	4	2
10 to 1	2	3	1
0	<i>the Register collapses; everybody loses</i>		

The premium for lying shrinks as the Register degrades. Falsehood is most profitable when the city can least afford it and barely worth the risk once the damage is done, which is the opposite of what everybody’s instincts will tell them.

6 Reading the Count

You know the Falsehood Count. You know how many black cubes you contributed yourself, which is none, one or two. Subtract yours to get the Remainder: the cubes that came from the other four Houses.

Remainder	Chance any given House lied
1	20%
2	39%
3	55%
4	69%
5	80%
6	89%

Below a Remainder of 3, challenging is usually a poor bet. Above 4 it is close to a duty. Between the two, it depends entirely on what you think of the person you are looking at.

Remember that a bought scribe contributes a black cube exactly as a liar does. An honest House under Pressure is indistinguishable from a dishonest one, and can never prove otherwise.

7 The Compact

At any time between rounds, three or more players may sign the Compact: a public undertaking to claim honestly, verified by a shared scribe.

Benefit Members gain +1 Influence on every honest claim.

Tariff Non-members pay 1 Influence to the bank whenever they trade with a member.

Threshold The Compact only functions with three or more members. At two, all benefits cease at once.

A member caught by challenge is sanctioned in steps, never all at once.

First A Warning token.

Second Loss of the verification bonus for two rounds.

Third Expulsion, and the seat cannot be reclaimed.

Size decides everything

With exactly three members, any single departure destroys the Compact for everybody, so every member holds a veto and knows it. With four, one may leave and it survives. The same act carries entirely different weight depending on how many are standing beside you.

8 Ending the Game

The game ends after the twelfth round, or immediately if Confidence reaches 0.

If the Register collapses, every player loses, including any who were eliminated earlier and any who were comfortably ahead.

Otherwise, each surviving player totals:

- Influence accumulated.
- 10 per Margin token.
- 5 if still a member of a functioning Compact.

Highest total wins. A player eliminated by Discredits scores nothing.

On winning

The winner is usually somebody who claimed honestly, policed the table, and was believed. The second most common winner is somebody who lied twice, very early, and was never challenged for it. Both should feel earned.

PLAYER AID

The round

1. Pressure. Draw a token, read it privately, return it.
2. Claim. Fist into the bag, release one. Retained cube under the cup *now*.
3. Scribe. Fist into the bag, release the colour your token dictated.
4. Count. Black cubes aloud.
5. Challenge. One only, and only if you claimed honestly.
6. Erosion. Confidence drops by the Count. All cubes back to the bag.

Reading the count

Remainder = Falsehood Count minus your own black cubes.

Remainder	1	2	3	4	5	6
They lied	20%	39%	55%	69%	80%	89%

Below 3, a poor bet. Above 4, close to a duty.

At the cup

WHITE under the cup	they played black. They lied.
BLACK under the cup	they claimed honestly.

Payouts

Confidence	36–31	30–21	20–11	10–1
Honest	2	2	2	2
False	6	5	4	3

Challenge correctly: they lose the action and take a Discredit; you gain 3.
Challenge wrongly: you take the Discredit. Three Discredits and you are ruined.